Steward — Design Brief and Brand Guidelines

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Design brief

Design Steward as a premium, durable and slightly playful tool: stainless steel and aluminium, quietly confident, never fussy.

Item	Brief
Product	Steward, the AI office manager (web app and Slack), and the Steward Bot, a handheld multi-tool with a camera, screen, voice and six folding tools
Audience	Office managers first; also budget holders, suppliers and staff who get pulled into problems
Brand idea	A serious tool that does not take itself too seriously
Feeling	Dependable, precise and calm under pressure, with a wink
Design language	Industrial design that is classic, minimal and led by material. Inspired by Teenage Engineering's playful rigour and Bang & Olufsen's restraint
Materials	Stainless steel and aluminium, in honest finishes
Constraints	Must work as a Slack avatar, on a 2.8-inch screen, etched into steel and on a desk; tough enough for a pocket and a toolbox; accessible contrast everywhere
Deliverables	These guidelines, a palette, type, voice, a logo direction, finish specs for the device and rules for the interface

The tension to hold. Premium, durable and playful pull against each other. The rule that settles it: the silhouette and materials are calm and precise, and the playfulness lives in details, words and sounds, never in the shape.

Three tests every design must pass

1. **Desk test:** would someone leave it on their desk instead of in a drawer?

2. **Squint test:** is it recognisable as Steward when blurred to a silhouette?
3. **Crisis test:** can someone read the critical screen at a glance, with one hand, under stress?

Brand essence

Steward is the dependable tool in the office drawer that happens to be clever: precise in a crisis, light-hearted the rest of the time.

Positioning line: *The office manager's pocket tool.*

Tagline options (pick one after testing)

- Fix it. Log it. Move on.
- Sees it. Fixes it. Remembers it.
- The tool your office forgot it needed.

Personality. Steward is a good engineer: calm, exact, a little dry, and happy to show its working.

We are	We are not
Precise, calm, dependable	Cold, clinical, corporate
Premium in material, modest in manner	Luxury for show, or flashy tech
Playful in the small things	A mascot, or a cartoon assistant
Durable and repairable	Disposable gadget design
Honest about what we know and don't	Magic, or "AI-powered" hype
Minimal	Bare. Every part earns its place

Brand promise: Steward does the small things so you can do the big ones, and it tells you plainly what it did.

Design principles

Six rules decide the hard calls; when two conflict, the lower-numbered one wins.

1. **Tool first, gadget second.** If a detail does not help someone fix something, remove it. It should feel like a tool someone has owned for ten years.
2. **Honest materials.** Steel looks like steel and aluminium like aluminium. No fake textures, no painted-on metal, no plastic dressed up as metal.

3. **Show the function.** Every control is labelled, etched or obvious. Nothing is hidden behind a gesture that cannot be learnt in one try.
4. **Calm by default, loud only when it matters.** The product is quiet and neutral until something is wrong, and then it is clear. Colour and sound are saved for meaning.
5. **Playful in the details.** A wink in the microcopy, a satisfying click, a surprising colour on a key. Never in the silhouette, and never during a critical issue.
6. **Built to be repaired.** Visible fasteners, replaceable battery and tools, parts that can be serviced. Durable is part of premium.

Materials and finish

The device is aluminium for the body and stainless steel for everything you touch to work, with polish kept for a few small jewels. Grades and processes below are design intent, to be confirmed with a manufacturer.

Part	Material	Finish	Why
Body shell	Aluminium, machined or extruded	Fine bead-blast, anodised	Light, cool in the hand, takes colour, wears well
Tools (all six)	Stainless steel	Brushed along the length, one laser-etched icon each	Hard-wearing and corrosion-resistant; the etch names the job
Tool cover plate	Smoked clear window	Gloss	Lets you see the tools folded, like a watch caseback
Scroll wheel and keys	Aluminium or stainless	Machined knurl; one anodised accent colour on the push-to-talk key	Tactile, instantly findable by thumb
Camera barrel	Stainless steel with dark glass lenses	Brushed barrel, polished lens ring	The "eyes" are the one place polish earns attention
Screen	Chemically strengthened glass	Oleophobic coating	Scratch- and fingerprint-resistant
Fasteners	Stainless Torx	Visible, four on the back	Honest and serviceable; a feature, not a flaw
Pivot pins	Stainless steel	Polished heads	Signals the knife heritage

Part	Material	Finish	Why
Seals and feet	Silicone	Graphite or accent	Absorbs knocks, keeps it from sliding off a desk

Finish rules

1. Two finishes per face at most: one matt, one brushed. Polish is jewellery, used only on pins and the lens ring.
2. Edges are slightly broken (a small chamfer or radius) so they catch light and never feel sharp.
3. Engraving, not printing, for anything permanent: icons, labels, serial number.

Colourways

- **Natural:** clear-anodised aluminium that reads as raw metal. The hero finish.
- **Graphite:** dark anodised, for offices that want it quiet.
- **Signal:** one playful limited colour on the body, such as yellow or green, with the same steel tools.

Durability intent (targets to set with the manufacturer): survives desk-height drops, pocket and toolbox carry without visible wear, and can be wiped clean with office cleaner.

Industrial design language

A calm slab with one big radius, a strict grid and a few tactile controls, where each surface does one job. We borrow principles from our references, not their looks.

Inspiration without imitation

Reference	What we take	What we leave
Teenage Engineering	Playful rigour: a visible grid, labelled functions, tactile controls, one bright accent, mono labels	Their signature colours and toy-like graphics
Bang & Olufsen	Material honesty, sculptural calm, machined aluminium, finish that rewards touching	Luxury signalling and hi-fi cliches
Swiss Army knife	Tools stacked on shared pivots, everything folds away, built to last decades	Red plastic scales and feature clutter

Reference	What we take	What we leave
Rabbit R1	The card-stack screen, side wheel and push-to-talk as a quick, physical way to talk to AI	The all-orange, gadget look

Form rules

1. **One outer radius** for the body (6.5 mm in the concept model). Inner details derive from it; no mixed small radii.
2. **A 4 mm grid** governs the position of every control, label and fastener.
3. **The front face is the screen** plus a mic and speaker slot row and one LED. Nothing else.
4. **All controls live on the edges**, under the thumb: a scroll wheel and a push-to-talk key, with USB-C on the opposite edge.
5. **Symmetry is broken once**, by the wheel and key on the right. That asymmetry is the device's personality.
6. **The back is the tools.** A flat spine with a smoked window, four visible Torx screws and two polished pivot pins.

Playful details (small, repeatable, never in the silhouette)

- A wheel with real detents and a soft mechanical click.
- A camera barrel that ratchets round, and "looks up" when it is listening.
- A consistent line-icon style for the etched tools, with one deliberately cheeky icon, such as the jam grabber's frowning sheet of paper.
- An engraved serial that reads like a name: *No. 0042, Steward*.
- A tool-roll style box that unfolds to a one-line hello.

Colour

The palette is the metals themselves, with Steward Green for the brand and Signal Yellow for the moments that matter to a voice or a key.



palette · 11 colours in 3 groups, hex values and roles

Rules

1. Most of any screen or surface is a material neutral. Colour is the exception.
2. **Steward Green** is the brand and the main action. **Signal Yellow** is reserved for voice, live states and the push-to-talk key.
3. The four severity colours mean severity and nothing else; never use them as decoration.
4. Signal Yellow is a fill, never text or a thin line. On Paper or Aluminium it only reaches 1.3 : 1, so give it a steel border or set it on Graphite.
5. In dark mode, surfaces use Graphite and Ink, the green lifts to a lighter tint (#5CC0A4) and the severity colours lighten to keep contrast.

Contrast checked (WCAG relative luminance, normal text needs at least 4.5:1)

Pair	Ratio	Use
Ink on Paper	15.5 : 1	Body text
Ink on Aluminium	13.4 : 1	Text on cards

Pair	Ratio	Use
White on Steward Green	6.0 : 1	Primary buttons
Steward Green on Paper	5.5 : 1	Links and active states
Ink on Signal Yellow	11.6 : 1	Text on the yellow key or chip
White on Alert Red	6.0 : 1	Critical badge
White on Focus Orange	4.6 : 1	High badge
White on Circuit Blue	6.5 : 1	Normal badge
White on Quiet Grey	5.1 : 1	Low badge

Hex values are design proposals; the anodising and print colours need matching to physical samples.

Typography

Two families do everything: a clean grotesque for reading and a monospace for anything that looks etched or measured.

- **Geist Sans** for headings, body and the wordmark. It is open source (SIL Open Font License) and already used in the prototype.
- **Geist Mono** for labels, ticket IDs, specs and anything engraved. Mono is the nod to Teenage Engineering's labelled grids.
- Fallback: the system UI font. Never a serif, and never a third family.

Role	Size	Weight	Use
Display	40	600	Hero lines, device boot screen
Title	28	600	Page titles
Heading	20	600	Section titles, card titles
Body	16	400	Reading text
Small	14	400	Secondary text, table cells
Label	11, mono, caps	500	Etched-style labels, ticket IDs, units

Rules

1. Two weights only, 400 and 600.

2. Sentence case everywhere. All caps is only for mono labels, with +8% letter-spacing.
3. Numbers use tabular figures so columns line up like a spec sheet.
4. On the device screen, nothing under 16 px equivalent, and the critical state uses the Display size.

Voice and tone

Steward sounds like a good engineer on your side: short sentences, plain words, a dry wit that switches off as the stakes go up.

The playfulness dial. The more serious the issue, the less Steward jokes. The same dial sets the spoken voice.

Severity	Tone	Spoken voice	Example
Critical	Calm, plain, no humour	Calm and steady	"Fuse tripped, circuit 7. Unplug everything in the kitchen, then find switch 7."
High	Focused, no jokes	Clear and focused	"The meeting-room access point is offline. Unplug port 3 for ten seconds."
Normal	Friendly, light dry wit	Friendly	"The grinder's jammed. Tip out a third of the beans and give the burr a brush."
Low	Playful	Light and casual	"The Monstera is thirsty. Give it a drink, and I'll book the plant people."

Writing rules

1. **Say what you did, then what is next.** "I merged two reports into STW-118. Reset switch 7 next."
2. **Name the thing.** "The cyan toner", not "a consumable".
3. **Be honest about confidence.** "I'm 74% sure it's the grinder. Want to check the hopper?"
4. **Own mistakes briefly.** "That was the wrong supplier. Fixed, and I've told them."
5. **No hype.** Never "AI-powered", "seamless" or "supercharge". No exclamation marks in any critical or high message.
6. **Wit is dry, never cute.** No emoji in guidance, no baby talk, no pretending to be human.

Do say	Don't say
"Fixed. I told #office-help."	"Awesome news! Your issue has been resolved!"
"Nothing here. Nice."	"No tasks found."
"Escalated to Spark & Co, with the photo and what we tried."	"We have notified the relevant stakeholder."

Interface, motion and sound

The interface should feel like the device: flat, precise, tactile and quiet until something needs you.

Interface

1. **Flat and material.** Aluminium cards on a Paper background, 1 px steel borders, one corner radius per element family. No gradients, no drop shadows.
2. **Photos lead.** A ticket starts with the photo, because that is how the problem arrived.
3. **One primary action per screen**, in Steward Green. The rest are quiet outline buttons.
4. **Mono for the measured stuff:** ticket IDs, phone numbers, costs, units.
5. **Icons** are 1.8 px line icons with round caps, one consistent set.
6. **Severity is a dot and a label, never colour alone.** Critical also gets the Display type size on the device.
7. **Device screen:** a black card stack in the style of a physical index, one thumb-sized card per job, the urgent one on top.

Motion

- Mechanical, not bouncy: 150 to 250 ms, ease-out, things slide and click into place.
- The one flourish is a detent: a small, quick settle when a card or wheel position locks.
- Respect reduced-motion settings everywhere; nothing important depends on animation.

Sound (a direction to prototype, not a finished set)

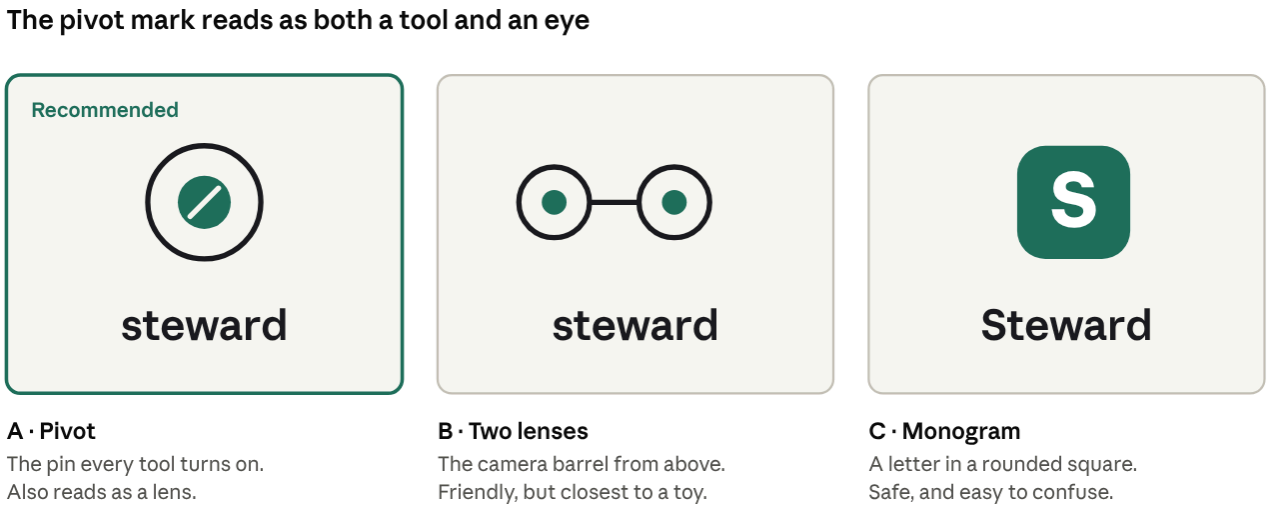
Moment	Sound
Wheel turn	A soft mechanical detent click
Voice listening	A short two-tone chirp, rising

Moment	Sound
Task fixed	A low, satisfying clunk, like a latch closing
Critical alert	One calm low tone, no siren, then the calm voice
Boot	A tiny click-and-chirp, under a second

Sound is always optional, and every spoken message also appears as text.

Logo and mark

Three directions are drawn below; the pivot mark is the recommendation because it is the one idea that comes from the product itself.



logo directions · 3 options, pivot recommended

These are working sketches to choose a direction from, not finished artwork; the final mark needs drawing and testing at small sizes.

Why the pivot. It is the pin every folding tool turns on, so it ties the brand to the Swiss Army heritage and the physical device. It also reads as a lens, which fits the camera. It etches cleanly into steel in one colour.

Rules for the chosen mark

1. **Wordmark:** lowercase "steward" in Geist Sans, weight 600, with the pivot mark beside or above it.
2. **Clear space** equals the diameter of the inner pin on every side.
3. **Minimum size:** 16 px on screen and 6 mm etched.
4. **Colour:** Ink on Paper or Aluminium; white on Graphite or Steward Green. One-colour version (ring and slot only) for etching and stamping.

5. **Never** stretch, outline, add gradients or shadows, or place the mark on a busy photo.

Do and don't, and references

When a design choice is unclear, check it against this table first.

Do	Don't
Show real metal finishes, lit from one side	Fake brushed-metal textures or chrome gradients
Use the grid and one radius	Mix many corner radii or free-float elements
Keep the front clean: screen and nothing else	Add decorative lines, badges or logos on the front
Spend playfulness on details, words and sound	Make the silhouette cute or toy-like
Reserve colour for meaning	Colour things just to liven them up
Etch labels and icons into the metal	Print them on in a way that wears off
Make repair visible and easy	Hide fasteners behind glue or stickers
Keep critical messages plain and calm	Use humour, hype or alarm styling when it is serious

References to study (for principles, not to copy)

- **Teenage Engineering:** the OP-1 and the Pocket Operator range, for labelled grids, tactile controls and the single accent colour.
- **Bang & Olufsen:** the Beosound A1 and Beolit, for machined aluminium, quiet proportions and finish.
- **Victorinox and Leatherman:** the Swiss Army knife and the Wave, for stacked tools and decades-long durability.
- **Braun:** the T3 pocket radio, for calm layouts and one thing per surface.
- **Rabbit R1:** the card-stack screen, side wheel and push-to-talk, as a model for talking to AI with your thumb.

Build a moodboard in three groups, **metal and finish**, **controls and labels**, and **small jokes**, and keep it next to the 3D model while designing.

Applying this

The app already matches much of this; the 3D device now follows the finish rules, and the remaining gaps are the app's yellow accent, the new mark and the sound set.

Area	Today	Change	Where
3D device	Done: anodised aluminium body, stainless tools	Review against physical finish samples. Built in: four colourways, knurled wheel and key, four Torx screws, etched tool icons and mark	`src/components/device/model.ts`
App colour	Green and neutral tokens, severity colours	Add Signal Yellow for voice and live states only	`src/app/globals.css`
App type	Geist Sans and Mono	Use mono caps labels for IDs and units; two weights only	components using `font-mono`
Logo	A letter S in a green square	Replace with the chosen mark and wordmark	`StewardMark` in `src/components/ui.tsx`
Microcopy	Calm lines throughout	Apply the playfulness dial: wit only at normal and low severity	`src/lib/agent.ts` voice lines
Sound	Browser speech only	Prototype the five sounds in the sound table	new, in the device page

Next steps

1. Choose a tagline and a logo direction (see the logo section).
2. Build the moodboard in the three groups above.
3. Review the reworked 3D model against the three tests and adjust.
4. Get physical finish and anodising samples to check the palette against real metal.

5. Prototype the sound set and the playfulness dial on the demo scenarios.
6. Review the finishes and durability intent with a manufacturer before committing to materials.